

Women's Inclusion in Post-Conflict Colombia

Q: Discuss the challenges to promote inclusion in conflict-affected states. (Empirically, use examples of women's inclusion OR inclusion of minorities in peace processes)

The inclusion of women is often recognised as a considerable factor in promoting sustainable peace in conflict-affected states. Many scholars have demonstrated women play an active role in the conflict-resolution process, post-conflict reconstruction, and so on (such as Dayal and Christien, 2020; Krause et al., 2018). Attention to women in conflict-affected states has been growing, especially after a series of United Nations Security Council (UNSC) resolutions advocating for the inclusion of women in peace processes, where these resolutions are collectively known as the Women, Peace, and Security Agenda (Adjei, 2019). Although there are more and more peace agreements that recognize the role of women, many challenges remain to the inclusion of women in conflict-affected areas. To explore the challenges of women's inclusion in-depth, this essay will use the case of Colombia. Colombia has undergone one of the longest civil wars in the Western Hemisphere, which began in 1964 and ended in 2016, lasting for 50 years (Suárez-Baquero et al., 2022). The Colombian civil war involved multiple forces, while the main tension in the civil war was between the Government of Colombia and the Revolutionary Armed Forces of Colombia (known as FARC-EP) (Céspedes-Báez and Ruiz, 2017). The Government of Colombia had struggled in negotiating and reaching a peace agreement with the FARC for many years (Céspedes-Báez and Ruiz, 2017). In 2012, the negotiations for the peace agreement began and it was reached in September 2016, declaring the end of the civil war (Céspedes-Báez and Ruiz, 2017). To delve into the Colombian civil war, violence against women cannot be ignored, where 4,151,416 victims (49.73%) of the armed conflict were women, and 3,780,677 of them were forcibly displaced (Suárez-Baquero et al., 2022). It is valuable to explore the challenge of women's inclusion. Therefore, the essay will discuss these challenges in detail arguing that women's inclusion is challenged on multiple levels in conflict-affected states. Firstly, the essay will begin with a discussion of the difficulties encountered by women in negotiating the peace agreement. Additionally, this essay will discuss the challenges that ex-combatant women and rural women face in integrating into Colombian society. Finally, it will present the difficulties of women's inclusion in the implementation of the peace agreement.

In the case of Colombia, women made a considerable effort to involve themselves in the negotiation of the peace agreement. Initially, women were excluded from the negotiation at first, while a significant number of men could participate with easier access. At the beginning of the negotiation between the Colombian government and the FARC-EP in August 2012, there were only men on the main negotiating team for both sides – only two women as alternate negotiators on the Colombia government side and only two women as collaborators on the FARC-EP side (Henshaw, 2023). To express women's dissatisfaction with the composition of the negotiators, many female organizations formed a coalition to voice women's demands (Henshaw, 2023). They desired women to participate in the peaceful negotiation and fight for women's dignity and rights (Henshaw, 2023). In November 2013, more than 8,000 women marched on the presidential palace in Bogotá (the capital city of Colombia) to put pressure on the government, leading to Colombian President Santos announcing that women would be included in the main negotiating team (Henshaw, 2023). Céspedes-Báez and Ruiz (2017) argue that the membership of the initial negotiating team was almost entirely linked to the armed services or the defense sector, showing a belief that people directly related to the war would make the talks go easier. Enloe (2014) further argues that the armed service and the defense sector are perceived as places where masculinity gains together. Therefore, this belief reflects a bias towards men in peace negotiations, as the experience of masculinity is favoured in the selection of peace negotiators. In the case of Colombia, women have made significant efforts to be involved in the peace negotiations. Indeed, the first peace negotiation began in August 2012 and after more than one year, in November 2013 the government finally showed its attitude in promoting the inclusion of women. Moreover, even if women were involved in the negotiation and expressed their opinions, the achievements related to women's rights still were eroded. The peace agreement was signed in September 2016 and there was a subsequent referendum in October 2016 (Céspedes-Báez and Ruiz, 2017). Unluckily, the peace agreement was narrowly rejected. Those who voted no in the referendum felt that the agreement contained Lesbian, Gay, Bisexual, Transgender, and Queer (LGBTQ) provisions that were unacceptable and needed to be changed (Céspedes-Báez and Ruiz, 2017). While these objections were directed at the LGBTQ community, this backlash indirectly influenced the negotiation, forcing negotiators to reduce the gender to female versus male and to take a more conservative view of women's identities in the revised agreement (Céspedes-Báez and Ruiz, 2017). This reflects the limitations of Colombian society concerning gender issues, where attitudes toward gender traditions are still dominant. Opponents argued that the inclusion of the LGBTQ community

in the peace accords violated traditional family values, but this line of thinking limited the space for women's issues in the negotiations. As the referendum was voted down, issues of gender and sexual orientation were excluded and this part of the rights was eroded, and although women were able to gain more rights for themselves by participating in the negotiations, they were vulnerable to being sacrificed when it came to issues of traditional values. This section of the discussion shows that the inclusion of women in peace negotiations has two challenges. One is the inclusion of women themselves in the negotiating team, and the other is the tendency for gender-related rights to be marginalised after the negotiations.

The inclusion of female ex-combatants faces more difficulties than that of male ex-combatants and these problems are susceptible to neglect in Colombian society. In post-conflict society, female ex-combatants found it hard to integrate into Colombia's patriarchal society. According to Gutiérrez and Murphy (2022) Although no female had attained higher military leadership positions, 33 percent of combatants from FARC-EP were female. This suggests that when the peace agreement was signed in 2016, there would have been a large number of female ex-combatants that factored into Colombia, a highly patriarchal society, posing a huge challenge to sustainable peace (Meger and Sachseder, 2020). Gutiérrez and Murphy (2022) Interviewed many female ex-combatants and stated that in post-conflict society, many females ex-combatants broke up with their husbands because many of these males would want them to stay at home to raise the children, do the housework, and so on. There were also part of some female ex-combatants who stated that the reason they joined FARC-EP in the first place was to escape from the abuse in their families, but the conflict ended and they had to go back to their families to continue experiencing these traumas (Gentry and Sjoberg, 2015). Patriarchal social norms were the primary dilemma for the female ex-combatants in their post-conflict integration into Colombian society. In the aftermath of the Colombian civil war, they had to readjust to an environment imbued with traditional notions of masculinity. During the war, they were allowed to fight, and in the aftermath, their roles were bound by traditional notions. The patriarchy only wanted their role to be limited to the family. This left many female ex-combatants feeling miserable and unable to adapt. In addition to adaptation challenges, female ex-combatants may face social stigmatisation. Rhyn (2019) argues that for members of the Colombian guerrilla, these former female combatants are seen in the social imagination as murderers, kidnappers, terrorists, rapists, and criminals. Such stigmatisation leaves former female combatants denied integration into society. When they return home after the civil war, for example, they

are dispossessed of their land and their parents' inheritance. Some former female guerrillas claim in some interviews that this is because the men are afraid of women who disobey them and take up arms (Lopera-Arbeláez, 2023). On the contrary, male guerrillas are welcomed back to their hometowns after the civil war is over. Lopera-Arbeláez (2023) argued that this occurs due to gender inequality in Colombia, where male ownership of guns is seen as strength, power, and status, while female ownership of the war is seen as humiliating and shameful by society. It demonstrates the stigmatising dilemma faced by female ex-combatants in Colombian society, resulting in stigma and rejection within their families and society. This stigmatisation is linked to their past armed participation, where men's possession of weapons is seen as a strength, while women are negatively evaluated and even ostracised, highlighting the structural gender inequality of Colombian society. Hence, female ex-combatants are a crucial part of the promotion of the inclusion of women, not only because of their numbers but also because of the challenges of stigmatisation they face.

Similar to female ex-combatants, the inclusion of rural women in Colombia also faces formidable challenges. Firstly, some cultural norms in Colombia magnify the vulnerability of rural women, subjecting them to increased risk of facing violence. Suárez-Baquero et al. (2022) argue that the prevalence of patriarchal cultural norms in Colombia has resulted in women being historically undervalued and more vulnerable in society. For example, it is common for family members to believe that punishing and physically abusing women is normal and even a sign of love in Colombia's rural regions (Cadena-Camargo et al., 2019). This cultural norm exacerbated the suffering of women during the Colombian civil war, leaving an indelible mark on the victims (Cadena-Camargo et al., 2019). More specifically, Cadena-Camargo et al. (2019) conducted in-depth interviews with five rural women from the Colombian civil war, all of whom had been victims of domestic violence and most of whom had experienced sexual violence. The cultural norm of emphasizing masculinity normalizes the violence against women, while armed conflict exacerbates the issue, increasing the harm inflicted on Colombian women. For women in Colombia's rural regions, they are more vulnerable to violence. Women first suffer inequality in the family, and as they are subjected to mistreatment in the family over time, they remember the pain of the violence and endure more of it. Also, men may think that violence against women is not unauthorised. In crises, women become the most vulnerable group, and violence is further exacerbated and justified in conflicts, putting women at risk. Therefore, reshaping these gender-relevant cultural norms that are rooted in Colombian rural areas is an urgent challenge to facilitate the

inclusion of women. Disrupted families and trauma in conflict-affected areas impede the participation of rural women in post-conflict reconstruction. The armed conflict significantly had a negative impact on families in those areas, where some family members were killed or still missing. Suárez-Baquero et al. (2022) argue that male families were likely to suffer such disappearances, leaving women alone to take care of their families. With the breakup of families, some women might sell everything looking for their family members so that they may face forced displacement (Suárez-Baquero et al., 2022). They consider that fear remains within the psyche and bones of those women who endure the armed conflict. After being forced into displacement, women would encounter many constant threats with other things, especially in Colombian society where females were usually neglected. In this circumstance, females were more likely to experience the unfavorable aspects of their environment than males. After the conflict, these fears would still root and take a leading role in female society. Therefore, these females cannot have a full effect on the post-conflict construction. Hence, how to address female fear and enable them to fully participate in the construction can be another challenge in Colombian society. By addressing these challenges and acknowledging the unique struggles faced by rural women in conflict-affected regions, avenues for meaningful inclusion can be created, fostering more comprehensive and enduring peace processes.

While the feminist movement has achieved substantial successes during the negotiation process in Colombia, these achievements have not been enough to ensure the fulfillment of the demands and recommendations contained in the Peace Agreements during the implementation phase. Firstly, the implementation of some of the provisions set out in the peace accord has encountered difficulties. For example, the peace agreement incorporated provisions to guarantee female rights in land access such as establishing preferential measures for women's access to the Land Fund, proposal of Development Plans with a Territorial Focus (PDET) to foster women's participation at a local level (Kroc Institute et al., 2019). However, After the signing of the agreement, the content on land issues was minimal in practice (Gómez and Montealegre, 2021). Gómez and Montealegre (2021) argue that referring to the land issue, people are unaware of the more than 100 provisions relating to women that have been agreed upon in the peace agreement. Some local authorities believe that the implementation of the agreement is the responsibility of the national government, and even if some of them have the political will to implement the provisions, they do not have access to the institutional resources necessary to do so, nor do they have the necessary

institutional dialogue between the national and regional levels. The difficulties in implementing the land-related provisions of the peace agreements, for example, show that it is a complex issue to enhance women's inclusion even when there is a peace agreement. This is because women's inclusion does not only involve the provisions mentioned in the peace agreement but also part of social life. Only when the content of the peace agreement is implemented it will be possible to demonstrate further progress in the inclusion of women in Colombia. Secondly, the willingness of the ruling government to implement the peace agreement is also an impediment to the issue of inclusion. After the entry into force of the peace agreement, it was left to the Duque government to implement it; however, when it did so, it did not do so following all the provisions of the treaty, but only to the bare minimum (Gómez and Montealegre, 2021). The most significant of these were limited to the political concealment of FARC-EP's contribution to peace, arguing that the members of the Colombian government had mainly protected the rights of victims. The peace agreement has many provisions on women's rights and the Duque government has failed to implement this part. This may be because the Duque government has cut the budget for the implementation of the agreement and has limited how it disseminates dialogue with civil society (Gómez and Montealegre, 2021). As can be noticed, the willingness of the ruling government to implement is also a challenge for the inclusion of women. Therefore, the Colombian government's attention to and implementation of provisions related to the inclusion of women cannot be ignored. Further, as discussed earlier about the inclusion of female ex-combatants and rural women, government policy responses and implementation will go some way towards facilitating their inclusion in Colombia's post-war society and achieving sustainable peace. Overall, this section argues that although the peace agreement was eventually signed, many provisions were signed but not implemented. The issue of implementation constitutes a major challenge for women's inclusion in post-conflict Colombia.

In conclusion, as an integral part of society, women are essential for the reconstruction of post-conflict areas. This essay uses the case of Colombia, discussing the challenges in promoting the inclusion of women. It discusses the inclusion issue from four aspects. First of all, it presents women encounter considerable difficulties if they would like to play a role in the negotiation of the peace agreement and they have to be aware that some of their proposals may be discouraged. Secondly, it showcases that female ex-combatants would face challenges due to society may humiliate them. Furthermore, rural women, as one of the most vulnerable groups, also had to deal with many issues such as violence against women may have a deep-

rooted impact on them. Finally, when implementing the peace agreement, some gender-related provisions may be overlooked, and the ruling government may not pay attention to them. Therefore, this essay can draw a conclusion that the inclusion of women is a complex issue that needs a great effort by multiple actors such as the government, the society, the attitude of the public, and so on. To overcome these challenges, there is a pressing need for sustained efforts to reshape societal norms, address structural inequalities, and strengthen institutional mechanisms to ensure the comprehensive and enduring inclusion of women in conflict-affected states.

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